

The War Within

Parliament has become the arena for the ambitious Generation Next of the party to prove their leadership skills. The two frontrunners are locked in an intense battle for the top party job.

| By Bhavna Vij-Aurora |

When it appeared that things could not get any worse for the BJP, they did. Falling from tragedy to farce to bad comedy, the erstwhile party with a difference continues to be a study in how to turn defeat into a struggle for survival. Remember: it is not the survival of the party that once marked a historic shift in national politics. It's all about the survival of the fittest within the party itself. It all boils down to that inevitable question: who has got the smarts to be the next leader of the BJP? The Parliament has become the arena for the so-called Generation Next of the Indian Right to prove their leadership skills—and show their competitive spirit.

Immediately after Prime Minister Manmohan Singh ended his speech in the Lok Sabha justifying his joint statement with his Pakistani counterpart in Sharm el-Sheikh, deputy Leader of the Opposition Sushma Swaraj stood up and raised a question about an issue she thought was more relevant to the nation at the moment: climate change. That was indeed a shocker from a leader who is proposing her own name for the chairmanship of Standing Committee on External Affairs. Something more

SUSHMA SWARAJ

Deputy Leader of the Opposition, Lok Sabha

■ Spoke on demand for grants for MHA. Said allocation of Rs 100 crore for national security was insufficient.

■ Delivered motion of thanks to President's address; said the Congress's victory was due to circumstances.

■ Spoke on the need to make arrangements for food and shelter of pilgrims for Kailash Mansarovar yatra.

BOTH THE LEADERS BEHAVE AS IF THE POST-

immediate—preferably her views on the joint statement—could have been more appropriate. But Swaraj wanted to be an earth citizen. Maybe she wanted to impress the House with her knowledge of subjects that are inseparable from global diplomacy.

Ever since she was made deputy leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha and Arun Jaitley the Leader of the Opposition in the Rajya Sabha, it has been a battle of wits between two of the brightest among the GenNext.

Both have come to occupy centrestage after the party's humiliation in the Lok Sabha elections. Both think the post-Advani future belongs to them.

The comparison between the two has become fodder for the party leaders. They are managing the Houses in a spirit of cut-throat competition—whether speaking on important issues, organising speakers to participate in debates and ensuring the presence of party MPs in the House. When Swaraj introduced a hierarchy

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